G Grit + Grace Doula

FREE FAMILY EDUCATION · GUIDE 06

Supporting Her

A Partner & Support-Person Guide

A practical, inclusive guide for listening, preparing together, offering labor support, and sharing postpartum care.

Printable workbook · US Letter

GUIDE 06 · 01

Support begins with listening

The most meaningful support starts with asking what helps this person feel heard, respected, and safe. Plans may change. Stay curious, offer choices, and let the birthing parent lead preferences whenever possible.

Your role and the care team's role

A partner or support person can offer comfort, practical help, and communication support. Doulas provide nonclinical support. Diagnosis, treatment, and medical decisions belong with the birthing person and qualified healthcare professionals.

A NOTE FROM TEESEE

A Note from Teesee: A steady support person can help a family feel less alone by listening first and taking practical tasks off their plate.

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Learn communication preferences

Communication preferences

What helps them feel heard?	Words or touch they welcome
Words or touch to avoid	How to offer choices
Who should receive updates	How to handle quiet or privacy

Try

- Ask before touching or offering a technique
- Use short, calm options rather than many questions at once
- Reflect what you heard and check you understood
- Speak to the parent, not over them

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Prepare together before birth

Pre-birth responsibilities

Facility and route information	Bag and document location
Transport and backup driver	Child, pet, or home arrangements
Care-team phone numbers	How to share preferences with staff

Checklist

- [ ] Review the parent's preferences together
- [ ] Ask what jobs they want you to handle
- [ ] Know when to contact the clinical team
- [ ] Plan for food, water, breaks, and your own support

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Offer practical labor support

Comfort may include a calm presence, helping change position, offering water if permitted, counterpressure if welcomed, reducing interruptions, or contacting the care team. Ask first and follow staff guidance. What helps can change from one moment to the next.

Labor support reference card

Ask: What would feel helpful right now?	Offer one option, then pause
Respect no, stop, or a change of mind	Contact the care team about clinical questions
Keep phone/contact plan accessible	

Comfort is not a performance

You do not have to make every sensation go away. Listening, staying nearby, and respecting choices are meaningful support.

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When the plan changes

Birth can unfold differently from expectations. If a new option or unexpected circumstance arises, help create space for the parent to ask questions and communicate preferences. Follow the clinical team's instructions and the parent's decisions.

Helpful questions for the care team

- Can you explain what is happening in plain language?
- What are the options and time considerations?
- What are the benefits, risks, and alternatives for this situation?
- Can we have a moment to discuss, if time allows?

Reflection

What can I say that reassures without making promises about the outcome?

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Support after birth

Practical care

- Prepare food and water
- Handle laundry and dishes
- Coordinate visitors
- Help with transport and appointments

Parent and baby support

- Ask what kind of rest or company is wanted
- Help contact clinicians when asked
- Share baby-care tasks as agreed
- Respect feeding and recovery plans

Postpartum task roster

Task	Person responsible
Backup	Time/check-in

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Notice when more help is needed

Listen seriously when the birthing parent says something feels wrong. Offer to call their healthcare professional or emergency services and stay with them if they want. Serious maternal warning signs can occur during pregnancy and up to a year after birth.

Get immediate medical care for warning signs such as

- Severe headache or vision changes
- Trouble breathing, chest pain, or a fast heartbeat
- Fever of 100.4°F (38°C) or higher
- Heavy bleeding, severe abdominal pain, or one-sided leg pain/swelling
- Thoughts of harming themselves or the baby

> **Emergency**
>
> For a life-threatening situation, call 911. In the U.S., call or text 988 for a mental health crisis. Do not delay urgent care while trying to decide what a symptom means.

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Emergency contacts and seven-day commitment

Emergency contacts

Birthing parent's clinician

Birth location

Baby's clinician

Trusted backup support

Emergency services

Other

Seven-day support plan

One task I will own each day

When I will check what is useful

How I will protect parent rest

Who I can ask to help me

One change I will make if needs shift

Optional reflection · Galatians 6:2

A reference for readers who welcome Christian encouragement; support can be offered across beliefs and family structures.

Sources and further reading

How a Doula Supports Your Partner
Grit + Grace Doula

Urgent Maternal Warning Signs
Centers for Disease Control and Prevention — Hear Her

Hear Her: Support a Pregnant or Postpartum Person
Centers for Disease Control and Prevention

Educational information reviewed against these sources on October 14, 2026. Confirm current guidance with your qualified care team.

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